it will not acquiesce to India. This, for the Pakistan Army, is genuine and total defeat.' [22] It is this worldview that largely explains Pakistan's repeated military overextension. It explains also Pakistan's propensity to paint India as a perpetual aggressor. The army's profitable role in Pakistan's economy accounts for some of its continued exaggeration of Indian belligerence; a constant external threat is a good way for the military to profit financially too. [23] For all these reasons, a nuclear-armed, terrorism-supporting, revisionist Pakistan is a problem to be managed by India over the medium-term, not necessarily one to be resolved.

Priority 10. Engage Afghanistan

The hijacking of an Indian Airlines plane to Taliban-controlled Kandahar in 1999—and the release by India of terrorists in its custody in exchange for the hostages—serves as a potent reminder of the imminent threat to India of an unstable Afghanistan. [24] Since the toppling of the Taliban by US-led forces in 2001, India attempted to help rebuild Afghanistan as the country tried to emerge from decades of terrible conflict. For India, this often required it to work against the preferences of the United States and its allies and despite the best efforts of Pakistan and its terrorist proxies.

India's contributions to Afghanistan's state-building efforts were significant. In terms of hard infrastructure, India provided assistance for the Salma Dam (renamed the Afghanistan India Friendship Dam), transmission lines, hospitals, highways, and the Parliament building. Overall, India was among the largest providers of aid to Afghanistan between 2001 and 2021. The development of human capital was just as important. India hosted a large number of Afghan students in India and provided training for officers of the Afghan National Security Forces (ANSF). India also attempted to incentivize trade. Following Pakistan's reluctance to facilitate transit trade between India and Afghanistan over land, India used an air freight corridor to become the largest destination for high-value Afghan exports. Although India, Iran, and Afghanistan agreed to a trilateral trade agreement, and India developed a port at Chabahar to help access Afghanistan, progress was slow